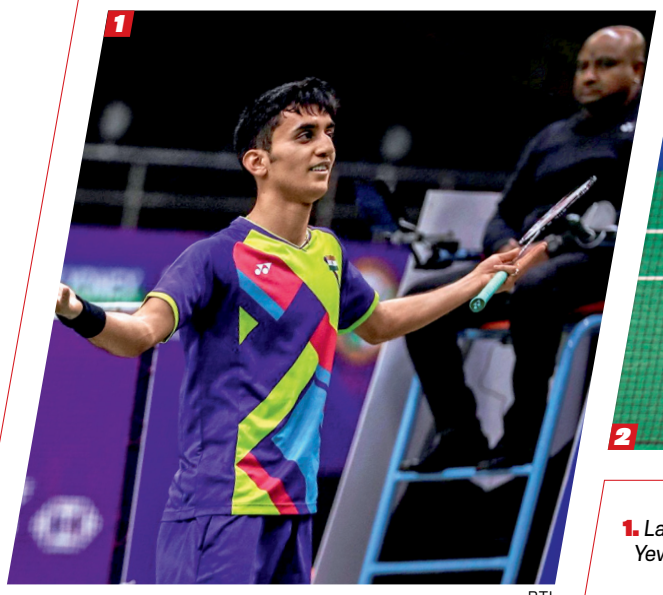


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1. *Lakshya Sen celebrates after defeating World Champion Loh Kean Yew in the men's singles final match at the India Open 2022, Jan. 16*
2. *Sen plays a shot against Loh Kean Yew at the India Open 2022 tournament*

Watching shuttler Lakshya Sen play can, at times, feel like watching a b-boy pulling off unbelievable moves. He will dive to retrieve a seemingly unreturnable shuttle and then quickly bounce back up to prolong the rally. You will gasp at his ability to switch from defence to offence. You might also wince, seeing what he is putting his body through. As he revisits his matches, Sen realises the risks he takes as he pushes himself. "There are chances of injury in shots where I throw myself on the court. I want to do it only when it is required and be more stable on my feet," he says. "But there's so much happening that you are not thinking, and then they turn into amazing rallies."

In the past two months, his inarguably exciting game has paid rich dividends for the 20-year-old. Sen won a bronze at his maiden World Championships as a senior in December. He recently bagged the India Open title in New Delhi, where he beat world champion Loh Kean Yew in the finals. Suddenly, the new kid on the block is in the spotlight. "It is great that people have been talking about me. I like the attention," says Sen. "But I just want to continue to perform at the highest level."

Sen is no overnight sensation though. A decade's work has gone into moulding him for the big stage. It was, perhaps, destined that the boy from Almora would pick up the racquet much like his grandfather, Chandra Lal, and father, Dhirendra Kumar Sen, had. "He was an intelligent kid who grasped [things] quickly," says Lakshya's father and coach, D.K. Sen. "My father used to say, 'make him a doctor'. Then he would see him play and say, 'He plays well, too.'" D.K. Sen saw his son had a spark but wondered if it was parental bias that made him see Lakshya as special.

In 2010, D.K. Sen travelled to the Prakash Padukone Badminton Academy (PPBA) in Bengaluru with his elder son Chirag and Lakshya. He asked coach Vimal Kumar for an "objective point of view" on Lakshya's talent. He didn't tell Kumar the boy was his son. "I could see that he was also impressed with his game," says D.K. Sen, who would soon send both his sons—aged 13 and 10, respectively—to PPBA for training.

Lakshya Sen used the lockdown to improve his stamina—playing basketball and football to improve his endurance

Lakshya's talent soon caught Padukone's eye. In 2017, Padukone, in an interview to ESPN.com, said, "I felt [Lakshya] had some very special qualities from the very beginning. The idea now is to help him keep developing tactically. I see my job as the one posing the questions, making him come up with the answers and I find he is faster at that than other players." The faith shown by Padukone and Kumar resulted in the Olympic Gold Quest (OGQ) investing in Sen since he was 11 years old. Sen delivered. After becoming the youngest to reach the national men's singles final at the age of 15 in 2017, beating Padukone's record in the process, he became the second Indian shuttler to win the Asia Junior Championships a year later. He followed this up with a silver at the 2018 Youth Olympics and bronze at the World Junior Championships.

No Indian male badminton player has won an Olympic medal. The pandemic spoilt Sen's plans to qualify for Tokyo 2020 as the international badminton calendar was severely disrupted in 2020-21. "For the Olympics [2020], I was not putting expectations on myself," says Sen, who began playing on the senior circuit only in 2019. He used the lockdown to improve his stamina. Post on-court and gym training, Sen played basketball and football to improve